

GENES ARE SELFISH MOLECULES

THE SELFISH GENE

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Richard Dawkins (1941–)

BEFORE

1963 British biologist William Donald Hamilton writes about the "selfish interests" of the gene in *The Evolution of Altruistic Behavior.*

1966 American biologist George C. Williams proposes in his book *Adaptation and Natural Selection* that altruism is a result of selection taking place at the level of the gene.

AFTER

1982 Richard Dawkins argues in *The Extended Phenotype* that the study of an organism should include analysis of how its genes affect the surrounding environment.

2002 Stephen Jay Gould critiques Dawkins' theory in *The Structure of Evolutionary Theory,* which revisits and refines the ideas of classical Darwinism.

The concept of the "selfish gene" was popularized by British evolutionary biologist Richard Dawkins in his 1976 book of that name. It states that evolution is fundamentally based upon the survival of different forms of a